technological gap between India and the West. It would prove a major error as Shahjehanabad's walls repeatedly failed to hold off attackers over the next two centuries.

Bernier describes the opulent palaces of the nobility with their courtyards and walled gardens. He tells us that the rich had raised pavilions set in the middle of flower-gardens and open on all sides to allow the breeze to flow from any direction. The insides of the private apartments had cotton mattresses covered in cloth in summer and carpets in winter. Cushions of brocade, velvet and satin were scattered around the rooms for the use of those sitting down. This matches what we can see in Mughal paintings and buildings that have survived from that time across northern India.

However, one should not get the impression that Delhi was a city merely of grand palaces and imperial mosques. The majority of the people of Delhi were common folk—shopkeepers, artisans, servants, soldiers and so on. These people lived in huts made of mud and straw that were built between and around the great palaces of the nobility. In other words, Shahjehanabad suffered severely from slums, that perennial problem of modern Indian cities. Bernier tells us that these slums gave the city the impression of a collection of many villages. Fires were common and sixty thousand roofs had been gutted in just one year (the number is probably an exaggeration, but point taken). The problem with fires had been described 1800 years earlier by the Greek ambassador Megasthenes when he visited Mauryan Pataliputra, but had yet to be solved in Mughal India. In other words, Mughal Delhi was a city of extremes. As Bernier puts it, 'A man must either be of the highest rank or live miserably.'

The Frenchman describes the bazaars as bustling, chaotic and dirty, not dissimilar to what Old Delhi looks like today. He tells us that there were many confectioners (i.e. halwais) all over the city but disapproved of the dust and the flies. There were also shops selling a variety of kebabs and meat preparations. Old Delhi remains home to some excellent kebab shops. The visitor can get off at the Chawri Bazar Metro stop and then take a five-minute rickshaw ride to the Jama Masjid area. Go late at night when the lane with the kebab- and sweet-shops throngs with people. With smoke